

Who Am I?

*A Personal Reflection Using the
RESPECTFUL Model*

Ben Forehand

[Course Number and Course Name]

[Professor Name]

[University Name]

September 2026

- R** RELIGION
- E** ECONOMIC CLASS
- S** SEXUAL IDENTITY
- P** PERSONAL STYLE
- E** ETHNIC IDENTITY
- C** CHRONOLOGICAL
- T** TRAUMA
- F** FAMILY
- U** UNIQUE PHYSICAL
- L** LOCATION & LANGUAGE



RESPECTFUL MODEL · ELEMENT 1 OF 10

RELIGION & SPIRITUALITY

My faith is foundational to how I understand people, thoughts, and behavior.

- I am a Christian and work at a nondenominational church.
- I view the Bible as the ultimate authority and a “North Star” for how I seek to live my life.
- Scripture teaches me to pay attention to the thoughts I entertain and where those thoughts eventually lead.
- I see a strong relationship between thoughts, feelings, and behaviors.
- As a counselor, my faith will shape who I am, but I also have a responsibility to understand the client’s values rather than impose my own.

KEY IDEA

Our thoughts influence our feelings, and our feelings can influence our actions.





RESPECTFUL MODEL · ELEMENT 2 OF 10

ECONOMIC CLASS & BACKGROUND

Economic status is part of a person's context, not a measure of their value.

- I have spent much of my career in large church environments with people from very different socioeconomic backgrounds.
- I have interacted with people who have far greater financial resources than I do, as well as people with far fewer.
- Earlier in ministry, I sometimes felt intimidated around people with significant wealth or influence.
- Those experiences helped me become more comfortable relating to people regardless of their financial status.
- As a counselor, I want to understand how finances affect stress, opportunities, relationships, and access to resources without making assumptions about the client.

MY RESPONSIBILITY

Meet the person in front of me, not the socioeconomic category I could place them in.

S

RESPECTFUL MODEL · ELEMENT 3 OF 10

SEXUAL ORIENTATION & GENDER IDENTITY

My role is to help clients pursue the goals that brought them to counseling.

- I believe I can work effectively with people whose sexual orientation or gender identity differs from mine.
- Effective counseling requires me to begin with the client's goals rather than my assumptions about them.
- Dysfunctional cycles, relational patterns, emotional needs, and personal growth are human experiences that cross demographic boundaries.
- My responsibility is to respect the client's dignity and listen carefully to their lived experience.
- I also need to remain aware of my own values and biases and seek supervision when they could interfere with effective care.

MY GOAL

Create a counseling relationship in which people feel respected, understood, and able to work toward meaningful change.



RESPECTFUL MODEL · ELEMENT 4 OF 10

PERSONAL STYLE & EDUCATION

Who I am as a counselor matters almost as much as what I know.

- A counselor’s personality, communication style, preferences, and biases inevitably enter the counseling room.
- Self-awareness is therefore an ethical responsibility.
- My personal style should be something I offer in service of the client, not something the client has to adapt to.
- If my style or preferences interfere with a client’s progress, I need to seek supervision, consultation, and continued growth.
- Education gives me greater knowledge and additional tools, but knowledge should improve the care I provide rather than create distance between me and the client.

WHAT I WANT TO PRACTICE

Competence with humility.



RESPECTFUL MODEL · ELEMENT 5 OF 10

ETHNIC & RACIAL IDENTITY

Difference gives me an opportunity to learn.

- I have spent much of my adult life in large, racially and ethnically diverse church communities.
- Relationships and vulnerable conversations with people who do not look like me have challenged prejudices and assumptions I previously held.
- Receiving friendship, care, and support across racial differences has also shaped how I see other people.
- I do not want to assume that familiarity with diversity means I have nothing left to learn.
- Every client whose experience differs from mine gives me an opportunity to understand both them and myself more deeply.

CORE BELIEF

Every person has inherent value and deserves to be treated with dignity.



RESPECTFUL MODEL · ELEMENT 6 OF 10

CHRONOLOGICAL & LIFESPAN CHALLENGES

People cannot be understood apart from the stage of life they are living in.

Childhood

EARLY TASKS

Adolescence

IDENTITY

Young Adulthood

INTIMACY

Middle Adulthood

GENERATIVITY VS. STAGNATION

Later Adulthood

INTEGRITY

- I currently identify with middle adulthood and Erikson’s stage of generativity versus stagnation.
- Questions about contribution, purpose, caring for others, and what I will do with my life feel especially relevant to me.
- Development does not stop when someone becomes an adult.
- Every stage of life introduces new pressures, responsibilities, relationships, and developmental tasks.
- Someone can function well for years and then become destabilized when a new life stage introduces challenges they have never faced before.

AS A COUNSELOR

I need to ask not only, “What is happening?” but also, “Where is this person in their life?”



RESPECTFUL MODEL · ELEMENT 7 OF 10

TRAUMA

My own experience has changed how I understand emotional pain.

- I have not experienced much of what I would consider “big T” trauma.
- I was raised in an emotionally distant environment where I sometimes experienced acceptance as conditional.
- Those experiences contributed to anxious attachment patterns that affected relationships into adulthood.
- Later, I began experiencing significant anxiety and panic attacks, including one in a very public setting while I was on stage.
- Not understanding what was happening made that experience particularly frightening.
- That journey became one of the reasons counseling and mental health became so important to me.

WHAT I CARRY INTO COUNSELING

My experience gives me empathy, but it does not mean another person’s trauma will look or feel like mine.

R E S P E C T F U L

(Ivey et al., 2023)



RESPECTFUL MODEL · ELEMENT 8 OF 10

FAMILY BACKGROUND

My family gave me one experience of family, not the definition of family.

- I grew up in a traditional two-parent household with an older brother and an older sister.
- My parents are still married, and our family was actively involved in church.
- I was raised with clear moral values and consider my childhood comparatively stable.
- Many clients will come from family structures and experiences that are very different from mine.
- Family structure alone does not explain someone's functioning.
- I want to understand the culture of the family, attachment patterns, expectations, roles, relationships, and systems of care that shaped the client.

IMPORTANT QUESTION

What did this person's family teach them to expect from themselves and from other people?

U

RESPECTFUL MODEL · ELEMENT 9 OF 10

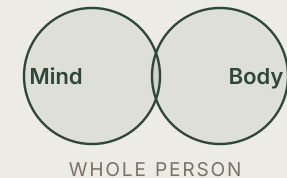
UNIQUE PHYSICAL CHARACTERISTICS

Mental health and physical health cannot be completely separated.

- Counseling must consider the whole person, including physical health, abilities, limitations, and body-related experiences.
- Sleep, movement, nutrition, breathing, exercise, and other physical practices can play meaningful roles in overall well-being.
- I want my recommendations to be grounded in evidence rather than simply my preferences.
- I also need to recognize cultural standards surrounding appearance, beauty, physical ability, and health.
- I cannot assume that what works for my body, lifestyle, or abilities will work for someone else's.

MY APPROACH

Use evidence-based care while adapting recommendations to the individual person.





RESPECTFUL MODEL · ELEMENT 10 OF 10

LOCATION & LANGUAGE DIFFERENCES

Language and culture are resources, not deficits.

- English is my primary language.
- I view bilingualism and multilingualism as strengths.
- Someone who has learned to navigate multiple languages or cultures has developed skills that should be recognized rather than treated as limitations.
- Geography also shapes experience. Rural, urban, regional, national, and cultural environments can create very different expectations and ways of understanding life.
- As a counselor, I need curiosity when someone's language, culture, or location differs from mine.
- Rather than assuming difference is a problem, I want to discover the strengths and resources that have developed through it.

MY ATTITUDE

Difference gives me something to learn, not something to correct.

REFLECTION

WHAT I LEARNED ABOUT MYSELF

This exercise showed me that effective counseling requires both self-awareness and humility.

- I bring my faith, family history, culture, education, experiences, assumptions, and personal style into every counseling relationship.
- Those parts of me can become resources, but they can also become blind spots.
- I need to continually recognize when my own preferences are influencing how I see another person.
- My experience is one human experience. It is not the standard by which another person's life should be measured.
- Understanding myself more clearly gives me a better chance of truly understanding someone else.

THE QUESTION SHIFTS FROM

“How is this person different from me?”



TO

“What do I need to understand about this person?”

CLOSING REFLECTION

WHO I WANT TO BE AS A COUNSELOR

The biggest lesson from the RESPECTFUL model is that I need to see the person before I see the category.

WHEN I ENTER THE COUNSELING ROOM, I WANT TO:

- Surrender assumptions about who someone should be.
- Remain curious about experiences I have not personally lived.
- Recognize the dignity and inherent value of every client.
- Use evidence, education, supervision, and self-awareness to provide responsible care.
- Help clients understand themselves, recognize unhealthy patterns, discover their strengths, and move toward the goals and values that matter to them.

FINAL THOUGHT

I want to see people clearly, value them deeply, and offer the best care I am capable of providing.

REFERENCES

Ivey, A. E., Ivey, M. B., & Zalaquett, C. P. (2023). *Intentional interviewing and counseling: Facilitating client development in a multicultural society* (10th ed.). Cengage Learning.

For the Bible passages used throughout the presentation:

English Standard Version Bible. (2016). Crossway. (Original work published 2001)